> About 8 a.m. the people of Mooshky and the adjacent villages assembled and suddenly came upon us with about 500 men. Armed with matchlocks and swords they came on making much noise and killed many of us. The remainder fled. We were all separated one in one fort and one in another. I heard that Lieutenant Crawford got on as far as Monee. When the 500 men came upon us I was stripped of everything, even to my clothes. After this I escaped to a short distance. About 5 p.m., two horsemen discovered my retreat and seized me and carried me off captive to a fort called Ghardeh.[44]

Soon after, Ghazni was surrounded and besieged by a large force of Ghilzais. Only Kandahar, under the watchful eye of General Nott, continued to remain peaceful. ‘I am not to be caught sleeping as my Kabul friends were,’ wrote Nott. ‘I have made every preparation for the safety of this part of the country.’[45]

In Kabul, meanwhile, the siege of the two vital commissariat forts was intensifying. On 3 November, Captain Trevor’s tower house opposite the Shah’s commissariat fort was stormed by the rebels soon after he and his family had escaped out of the back gate in the dark. Yet although the forts contained all the British food supplies that had been gathered for the long Afghan winter, neither Elphinstone nor Macnaghten sent any troops, or even further supplies of ammunition, to aid the defenders of either outpost, although both centres of resistance were less than a mile and a half from the cantonment where 5,000 armed sepoys were idly waiting for orders. ‘No military steps have yet been taken to protect our only means of subsistence in the event of a siege,’ wrote an increasingly frustrated Lady Sale in her diary. ‘This fort (an old crazy one, undermined by rats) contains the whole of the Bengal Commissariat stores. Should the Commissariat fort be captured, we shall lose not only all our provisions, but our communication with the city shall be cut off. The envoy and general still appear perfectly paralysed.’[46]

Brigadier Shelton was no more effective. ‘Shelton appeared from the commencement to despair of success,’ wrote Mohan Lal, ‘which produced a baneful effect in every fighting man.’[47] ‘Although already supplied with a force superior in numbers to that which had shortly before carried the strong fort of Qalat by assault in open day, Shelton had remained totally inactive,’ agreed George Lawrence. ‘Even so obvious an action as securing the [old Mughal] Shah Bagh and Mohammad Sharif’s fort [which overlooked the cantonment] was totally neglected, although these lay between us and that